

Which foods **really** drove the UK's food price rise?

Category price indices plus 75,858 shop-level price quotes, with every headline result checked against a published ONS figure.

+39.8%

food prices since Jan 2021 (all prices +31.7%)

19.2%

peak food inflation, Mar 2023

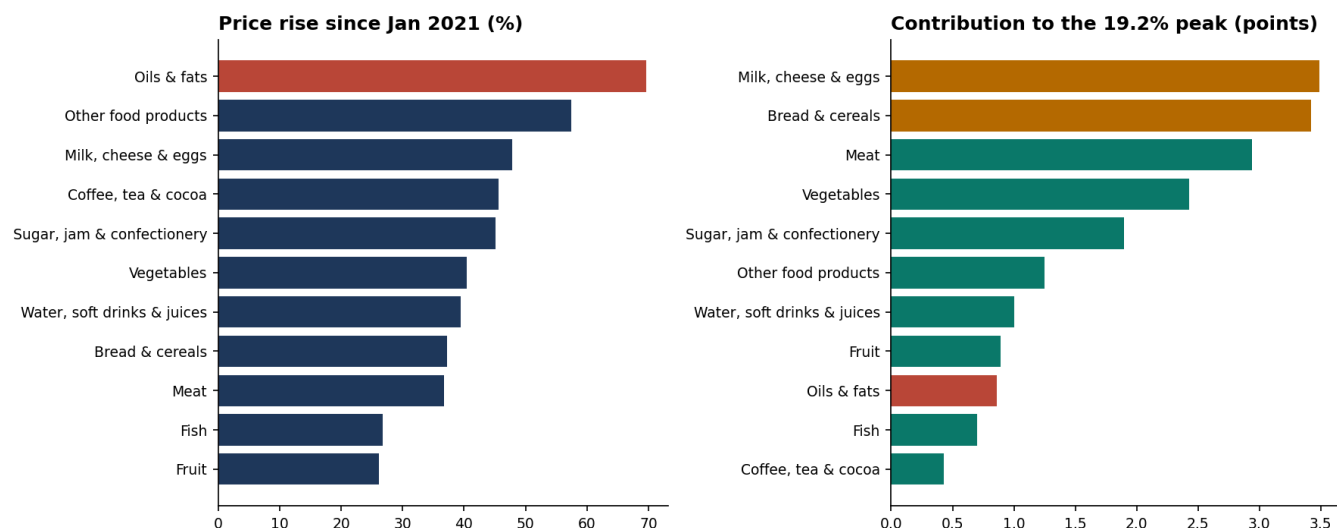
1.3%

food inflation now, below overall (3.1%)

33.4% / 34.4%

my like-for-like estimate vs official ONS, 2021–25

Biggest risers are not the biggest drivers



KEY FINDINGS

- **The biggest risers weren't the biggest drivers.** Oils and fats rose most (+69.7%) but added only 0.86 points to the 19.2% peak. Dairy and bread together added 6.9.
- **Like for like, the typical product rose 33.4%** (same product, same shop, 21,766 pairs). Olive oil +112%; honey +1%.
- **The squeeze was national:** 29.4% to 35.2% across all 12 regions.
- **Chains rose faster than independents** (30.6% vs 15.6%), a lead to explore given the small independent sample.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR A FOOD RETAILER

- **Staples set the price perception:** dairy and bakery moved the bill most.
- **The pressure has eased:** with food inflation below overall inflation, the focus shifts to value and quality.
- **Watch volatile lines:** oils and fats, dairy, and sauces and condiments peaked above 30% a year.

HOW IT WAS CHECKED

- Category contributions match the official food rate within 0.07 points on average.
- SQL and Python built side by side agree within 0.05 points; the cross-check caught one central price copied into 12 regions.